

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Bioluminescence is most commonly found among marine organisms: <u>76 percent of known luminescent species inhabit ocean environments</u>. This prevalence is thought to result from the unique selective pressures of the deep sea, where sunlight cannot penetrate and organisms must produce their own light to communicate, hunt, or evade predators.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It explains why bioluminescence evolved more frequently in marine environments than in terrestrial ones.

B: It introduces the central claim of the passage by establishing that bioluminescence occurs primarily in oceans.

C: It identifies the environmental pressures that drive organisms to develop light-producing capabilities.

D: It quantifies the claim made in the preceding clause about where bioluminescence is most commonly found.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: The first clause MAKES the claim ("most commonly found among marine organisms"); the underlined statistic SUPPORTS it with a number. B is the trap -- the statistic does not introduce the claim; it backs up a claim already stated. Ask: "Did the claim come before or after this sentence?"

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Sociologist Marco Pellegrini has found that neighborhoods with community gardens report higher levels of social cohesion than those without. Residents in garden-equipped neighborhoods were 35 percent more likely to know their neighbors by name and 28 percent more likely to participate in local civic meetings. Pellegrini suggests that shared outdoor spaces create informal opportunities for interaction that strengthen community bonds.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It explains the mechanism by which community gardens increase social cohesion among residents.
- B: It provides measurable evidence that specifies the nature of the social cohesion described in the preceding sentence.
- C: It presents Pellegrini's conclusion about why shared outdoor spaces strengthen community bonds.
- D: It introduces a comparison between neighborhoods with and without community gardens that the rest of the text analyzes.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is tempting because the passage does discuss why (last sentence), but the underlined DATA does not explain "why" -- it shows "how much." C confuses the data with the explanation (the last sentence is the explanation). The underlined portion specifies what "higher social cohesion" actually looks like in measurable terms.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The Library of Alexandria, founded in the third century BCE, was one of the largest repositories of knowledge in the ancient world. <u>Scholars traveled from across the Mediterranean to study its collection, which reportedly housed hundreds of thousands of scrolls.</u> The library's destruction, the causes and timing of which remain debated, represented an incalculable loss of accumulated learning.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It conveys the scope of the library's collection and its scholarly importance, reinforcing the characterization of it as a major repository of knowledge.

B: It provides historical context that primarily serves to set up the discussion of the library's destruction in the following sentence.

C: It contrasts the library's period of scholarly activity with the eventual decline of the institution described later.

D: It presents new evidence that historians have recently used to revise estimates of the library's size.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the big trap. The sentence DOES come before the destruction sentence, so it seems to "set up" that discussion. But the function is to REINFORCE the first sentence's claim about the library's significance, not to prepare for the destruction narrative. The destruction is a separate point. Ask: "Does this sentence support what came before it, or prepare for what comes after?"

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: <u>Many people assume that chameleons change color primarily to blend in with their surroundings,</u> but research by herpetologist Ana Reyes has shown that color change is more commonly triggered by social signals and temperature regulation. Reyes found that chameleons display their most vivid colors during territorial disputes and courtship, not when attempting to hide from predators.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It summarizes the findings of Reyes's research on chameleon color-change behavior.

B: It provides the central claim that the rest of the text is structured to defend with evidence.

C: It states a common belief that the text then counters with research evidence.

D: It acknowledges a limitation of earlier research on chameleons that Reyes's study was designed to address.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the trap. Students might think "the text is about this idea, so it must be the main argument." But the text's argument is the OPPOSITE of the assumption -- it uses Reyes's research to COUNTER it. The underlined portion is what gets overturned, not what gets defended. The word "but" right after the underlined portion is the signal.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: The following text is from Priya Desai's 2017 novel *The Orchard Gate*. Meera is reflecting on her childhood home.

<u>The house had been painted three times since she left, each coat a shade lighter than the last, as though the building itself were slowly forgetting its original color.</u> Meera stood at the gate, uncertain whether to knock. The woman who answered would not be her mother, and the kitchen would smell of someone else's cooking.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It establishes that Meera has been away from the house for an extended period and has kept informed about changes to the property.

B: It conveys Meera's judgment that the current owners have failed to maintain the house to her standards.

C: It introduces a detail about the house's exterior that the text then contrasts with a description of its interior.

D: It uses a physical change in the house to suggest that Meera's connection to her former home has diminished over time.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the best trap. The paint detail DOES imply she has been away a long time, so A seems plausible. But the key phrase is "as though the building itself were slowly forgetting" -- this is figurative language about loss and fading, not factual tracking of renovation. When the text uses "as though," it signals a figurative purpose, not a literal one.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Researchers studying memory consolidation have long known that sleep plays a role in transferring information from short-term to long-term memory. In a 2021 experiment, participants who slept for eight hours after learning a list of vocabulary words recalled 40 percent more words the following day than participants who remained awake. These findings support the broader hypothesis that sleep-dependent neural processes are critical for durable learning.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It extends the established view of sleep and memory by revealing a mechanism that previous research had not identified.

B: It presents the results of a specific study that reinforce the claim about sleep and memory stated in the first sentence.

C: It provides the basis for the hypothesis in the final sentence, which the researchers proposed only after observing the experimental results.

D: It qualifies the claim in the first sentence by showing that the effect of sleep on memory depends on the type of information being learned.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: C is tempting because the experiment appears before the hypothesis in the text, so students may think the experiment GENERATED the hypothesis. But the text says researchers "have long known" this (first sentence), and the final sentence says findings "support" the hypothesis -- meaning it existed beforehand. The experiment confirms, it does not create.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: Urban sociologist Claudia Ferreira argues that public transportation systems should be evaluated not just by ridership numbers but by accessibility metrics such as the percentage of jobs reachable within a 45-minute commute. By this measure, cities like Houston, where most employment centers are accessible only by car, perform poorly despite having extensive bus networks. Ferreira contends that ridership alone can mask deep inequities in transportation access.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It provides a specific case that demonstrates the practical implications of the evaluation framework Ferreira proposes.

B: It identifies a weakness in Ferreira's accessibility metric by showing that it does not account for existing bus infrastructure.

C: It presents a finding that Ferreira produced through a comparative analysis of transit systems in multiple cities.

D: It shifts the text's focus from a theoretical framework to a broader critique of Houston's urban planning decisions.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is tempting because Houston DOES have bus networks yet performs poorly -- students might read this as a flaw in the metric. But the passage treats this as the metric WORKING correctly: ridership looks fine, but accessibility reveals hidden problems. Houston illustrates the argument; it does not undermine it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Ecologist Soren Lindqvist studies the recovery of forests after volcanic eruptions. Conventional ecological theory predicts that pioneer species -- fast-growing plants that tolerate poor soils -- should be the first to colonize barren volcanic terrain. Lindqvist's fieldwork on a recently erupted island in the Pacific, however, revealed that slow-growing mosses and lichens established themselves first, creating a thin soil layer that pioneer species subsequently exploited. This finding suggests that the standard model of ecological succession may need revision for volcanic landscapes.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It summarizes the main finding of Lindqvist's fieldwork on volcanic landscapes.
- B: It defines the term "pioneer species" so that the reader can understand the significance of Lindqvist's discovery.
- C: It states an expectation from established theory that Lindqvist's subsequent findings call into question.
- D: It provides background on the general process of forest recovery that the text goes on to confirm with field data.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: D is the big trap. The underlined sentence IS about general ecological theory, so "provides background" sounds right. But D says the text "confirms" the theory, while the text actually CHALLENGES it with "however." The word "however" after the underlined portion signals that what came before is being contrasted, not confirmed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Luca Bianchi's 2020 short story "The Glassblower's Apprentice."

The master never praised a piece directly. If the vase held water without leaking and caught the light at the angle he wanted, he would simply nod and move to the next task. <u>It was the absence of correction, not the presence of approval, that told the apprentice he had succeeded.</u> Over time, the apprentice learned to read these silences the way a sailor reads calm seas -- not as emptiness, but as a sign that nothing was wrong.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It reveals the apprentice's frustration with the master's refusal to offer direct feedback on his work.

B: It articulates the principle by which the master's approval operated, which the following sentence then extends with an analogy.

C: It describes the standard of quality the master applied when evaluating the apprentice's glasswork.

D: It introduces a tension between the master and the apprentice that the analogy in the next sentence resolves.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: C is the best trap. The sentence mentions "succeeded," so students might think it is about what counts as quality work. But the function is about HOW approval was communicated (through absence of correction), not WHAT the quality standard was. The quality standard is in the preceding sentence (no leaks, correct light angle). This sentence is about the communication METHOD.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Psychologist Anya Morozova examined the effect of background music on task performance. Her study found that participants completed spatial reasoning tasks faster when listening to instrumental music at moderate volume than when working in silence. Participants who listened to music with lyrics, however, performed worse than both the silence and instrumental groups. Morozova suggests that lyrics compete for the same cognitive resources used in spatial reasoning, creating interference that instrumental music does not.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents the primary conclusion of Morozova's study about the relationship between music and cognition.

B: It describes a finding that undermines the broader claim that background music affects task performance.

C: It provides the evidence on which Morozova based her initial decision to investigate background music and cognition.

D: It introduces a result that complicates the preceding finding by showing that the effect of music depends on its type.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the biggest trap. The lyrics finding is striking and memorable, so students assume it must be the "main conclusion." But the study's overall picture involves BOTH findings (instrumental helps, lyrics hurt). The underlined sentence's function is to ADD COMPLEXITY to the initial finding, not to state the whole conclusion. The word "however" signals complication, not primacy.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The axolotl, a salamander native to lakes near Mexico City, can regenerate entire limbs, portions of its heart, and even sections of its spinal cord. Most vertebrates lose the capacity for significant tissue regeneration early in development, retaining only limited wound-healing abilities as adults. Biologist Carmen Vega has identified a set of genes in axolotls that remain active throughout their lives but are silenced in other vertebrates shortly after birth, a discovery that may explain the axolotl's exceptional regenerative powers.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It establishes what is typical among vertebrates in order to underscore the significance of the axolotl's regenerative ability.
- B: It describes a biological process that Carmen Vega's research has shown to be inaccurate for most vertebrate species.
- C: It identifies the specific developmental stage at which the axolotl's regenerative genes become active.
- D: It provides the scientific context necessary to understand the methodology Vega used to identify the relevant genes.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is tempting because Vega's research does relate to the norm stated here. But Vega does not show the norm is INACCURATE -- she shows the axolotl is an EXCEPTION. The norm is still true for most vertebrates; the axolotl's genes simply do not follow it. The underlined portion provides the contrast that makes the axolotl remarkable.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Archaeologist Lucia Torres discovered a cache of obsidian tools at a site in southern Chile dated to approximately 14,000 years ago. The nearest known obsidian source is located over 300 kilometers to the north, in a volcanic region of the Andes. Torres argues that the tools' presence at the site constitutes evidence of long-distance trade networks among early South American populations, a conclusion that challenges the view that such networks developed only after the advent of agriculture.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It explains the geological conditions that made obsidian suitable for tool-making in early South American cultures.

B: It provides a geographic detail from which Torres draws an inference about long-distance trade among early populations.

C: It offers an alternative to Torres's claim by suggesting that the obsidian could have originated from a source closer to the site.

D: It establishes the dating evidence that Torres uses to challenge the prevailing view about when trade networks emerged.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: D is tempting because the passage DOES discuss dating (14,000 years ago) and DOES challenge a prevailing view. But the underlined portion is about DISTANCE (300 km), not about DATING. The dating is in the first sentence. The 300 km gap is what implies trade -- raw materials do not travel that far on their own. Distinguish which detail supports which part of the argument.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Plant biologist Rena Okonkwo studies how trees allocate resources between growth and defense. <u>In nutrient-rich environments, trees tend to invest heavily in rapid vertical growth, producing thinner bark and fewer chemical defenses against herbivores.</u> Okonkwo's experiments showed that when she artificially reduced soil nutrients, the same tree species shifted resources toward thicker bark and higher concentrations of defensive compounds, suggesting a flexible trade-off mechanism rather than a fixed strategy.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents Okonkwo's central experimental finding about how trees respond to changes in soil nutrients.

B: It challenges the prevailing scientific view that trees follow a fixed resource allocation strategy.

C: It describes a general pattern of tree behavior that serves as a point of comparison for Okonkwo's experimental results.

D: It defines a technical concept related to plant biology that is essential for understanding Okonkwo's methodology.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the biggest trap. Students might think the nutrient-rich behavior IS Okonkwo's finding. But the text says "Okonkwo's experiments showed that when she ARTIFICIALLY REDUCED soil nutrients..." -- meaning the experiment changed conditions. The underlined portion describes what happens NATURALLY (the baseline). The word "tend" signals a general observation, not a specific experimental result.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Economist Tadashi Yamamoto has studied the effect of remote work on urban commercial real estate. He found that office vacancy rates in central business districts rose significantly between 2020 and 2023. Some analysts predicted that these vacancies would trigger a collapse in commercial property values. Yamamoto's data tell a more nuanced story: while mid-tier office buildings did lose value, premium properties with modern amenities maintained or even increased their rents, as companies competed for high-quality spaces to attract employees back to the office.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It introduces Yamamoto's own hypothesis about commercial real estate, which his data subsequently confirmed.
- B: It provides historical context about the commercial real estate market that explains why Yamamoto undertook his study.
- C: It summarizes the consensus view among economists that the text presents as still fundamentally accurate despite some exceptions.
- D: It presents a forecast that the text then shows to be an oversimplification of a more complex reality.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: C is the best trap. The prediction DID partially come true (mid-tier buildings lost value), so students might think the text "mostly confirms" the analysts. But the text says Yamamoto's data tell "a more nuanced story" -- meaning the prediction was TOO SIMPLE, not mostly right. A is wrong because the prediction comes from "some analysts," not from Yamamoto himself.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: The following text is from Aisha Kamara's 2019 essay collection *Maps Without Borders*.

My mother's English was grammatically imperfect but emotionally precise. She could describe a feeling in four words that would take me a paragraph to approximate. "The loneliness of airports," she once said, and I knew exactly what she meant -- not the solitude of being alone, but the particular ache of being surrounded by people who are all going somewhere else. I spent years in graduate school learning to write, and she still said more with less.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It offers a specific instance that demonstrates the quality of emotional precision attributed to the mother in the preceding sentences.
- B: It expands the scope of the narrator's argument by shifting from a claim about the mother's language to a broader reflection on loneliness.
- C: It reveals a disagreement between the narrator and the mother about the nature of loneliness and how it should be expressed.
- D: It transitions the text from a description of the mother's speaking style to a critique of the narrator's formal education.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the best trap. The underlined portion DOES discuss loneliness in depth, so students might think it is "expanding the scope." But the function is to EXEMPLIFY the claim, not to broaden it. The passage says the mother was "emotionally precise," and the airport quote is the proof. The loneliness discussion is not the point -- the point is that the mother captured it in four words.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: Marine biologist Kai Nakamura has proposed that the bright coloration of many reef fish serves not only as a warning to predators but also as a form of species recognition in the visually complex reef environment. In controlled tank experiments, fish consistently chose to associate with conspecifics (members of the same species) over similarly sized fish of different species, even when the only distinguishing feature was color pattern. Nakamura concludes that coloration functions as a social signal at least as much as a defensive one.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It reveals a limitation in Nakamura's experimental design that weakens the support for her species-recognition hypothesis.

B: It challenges the widely held view that reef fish coloration primarily serves as a warning to predators.

C: It describes the outcome of an experiment that supports the species-recognition component of Nakamura's proposal.

D: It demonstrates that color pattern is the most important factor in reef fish survival across all marine environments.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the best trap. Students might think the experiment "challenges the predator-warning view." But the text says coloration serves "not only as a warning... but also as species recognition" -- the experiment supports the ADDITION, not the REPLACEMENT. Nakamura does not argue against the predator-warning function; she argues there is an additional one.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: During the Industrial Revolution, child labor was widespread in British textile mills. Reformer Robert Owen, who owned several mills himself, argued that educating child workers rather than exploiting them would ultimately increase productivity by producing a healthier, more skilled workforce. Owen's model, implemented at his New Lanark mill in Scotland, combined reduced working hours for children with on-site schooling, demonstrating that humane labor practices and commercial success were not mutually exclusive.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It describes the standard labor practices of mill owners during the Industrial Revolution that Owen sought to reform.

B: It presents Owen's claim linking humane treatment of child workers to economic benefit, which the following sentence then illustrates with a specific implementation.

C: It introduces a criticism of Owen's approach to labor reform that the text ultimately refutes with evidence from New Lanark.

D: It provides quantitative evidence about child labor productivity that supports the text's argument about education and economic output.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the best trap. Owen "owned several mills himself," so students might think the underlined portion is describing what mill owners typically did. But Owen's argument was AGAINST typical practices -- he proposed an alternative. The underlined portion is Owen's OWN position. D is wrong because there are no statistics in the underlined portion.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Neurobiologist Fatou Sow has investigated how the brain processes conflicting sensory information. In everyday perception, the brain seamlessly integrates signals from multiple senses -- sight, sound, touch -- to construct a coherent experience of the environment. Sow's experiments, however, introduced systematic mismatches between visual and auditory stimuli and found that the brain does not simply average the conflicting signals but instead assigns dominance to whichever sense has historically been more reliable for the type of task at hand. This finding challenges earlier models that treated sensory integration as a simple weighted average.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It summarizes the main finding of Sow's experiments on how the brain handles conflicting sensory input.

B: It presents a claim that Sow's experiments were specifically designed to verify and ultimately confirmed.

C: It introduces a competing theory of sensory processing that Sow's research neither supports nor refutes.

D: It describes the standard model of sensory integration that Sow's subsequent findings reveal to be incomplete.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the hardest trap. The underlined portion describes something generally accepted, and students might think Sow's experiments confirmed it. But the word "however" signals that the experiments found something DIFFERENT from the standard model. Sow did not confirm seamless integration -- she showed it is more complex than previously thought. The underlined portion is the SETUP that gets complicated, not the conclusion that gets confirmed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is from Elif Bozkurt's 2021 novel *The Thread and the Needle*.

The tailor's shop had no sign. Locals knew where it was; strangers were not expected. Inside, bolts of fabric lined the walls from floor to ceiling, arranged not by color or pattern but by the occasion for which each cloth was typically used -- mourning silks beside wedding brocades, baptismal cottons next to burial linens. This arrangement struck visitors as morbid, but the tailor saw it as honest: life's ceremonies, he believed, were not as separate as people liked to pretend.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It catalogs an unconventional organizational scheme that the subsequent sentences interpret as an expression of the tailor's worldview.

B: It contrasts the tailor's system of organizing fabrics with the methods used by other textile merchants in the area.

C: It provides evidence that the tailor's business suffers from a lack of conventional commercial practices.

D: It establishes the physical setting of the shop before the text shifts to a discussion of the tailor's personal relationships.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the best trap. The arrangement IS unusual (by occasion rather than color/pattern), so students might think the text is COMPARING it with other shops. But the passage never mentions other shopkeepers. The phrase "not by color or pattern but by occasion" describes what the tailor chose, not what others do. The function is to present the arrangement so the next sentences can interpret it as reflecting a philosophy.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Climate scientist Ingrid Haugen has studied the effects of permafrost thaw on Arctic carbon cycling. As permafrost melts, organic matter that has been frozen for millennia becomes available to soil microbes, which decompose it and release carbon dioxide and methane into the atmosphere. Some researchers have estimated that permafrost regions store nearly twice as much carbon as the entire atmosphere currently contains. Haugen's modeling work, however, suggests that the rate of release will depend critically on local hydrology: waterlogged soils tend to produce methane, a more potent greenhouse gas, while drier soils release carbon dioxide, which is less potent but longer-lived.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

- A: It presents an estimate that Haugen's modeling work has shown to be significantly overstated.
- B: It describes the methodology that researchers used to calculate how much carbon is stored in permafrost.
- C: It conveys the magnitude of carbon stored in permafrost, emphasizing the potential significance of the release process described in the surrounding text.
- D: It introduces a finding that contradicts the claim made in the preceding sentence about how permafrost decomposition occurs.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the hardest trap. Haugen's work comes after with "however," so students might think she is correcting the estimate. But Haugen does not dispute HOW MUCH carbon is stored -- she adds nuance about HOW it will be released (methane vs. CO2 depending on hydrology). The "however" contrasts with the implied simplicity of the release, not with the amount of carbon.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Political theorist Kwesi Mensah has examined how colonial-era legal frameworks continue to shape property rights in postcolonial nations. <u>In many formerly colonized countries, customary land tenure systems -- in which communities rather than individuals held rights to land -- were supplanted by colonial property laws that recognized only individual ownership documented through formal titles.</u> Mensah argues that this legacy creates ongoing conflicts between communities claiming ancestral rights and governments enforcing title-based ownership, and he calls for hybrid legal frameworks that recognize both systems.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents Mensah's proposed solution for resolving disputes between community-based and title-based ownership systems.

B: It traces the historical process that, according to Mensah, created the property rights conflicts the rest of the text discusses.

C: It argues that customary land tenure systems were inefficient compared to the formal title systems that colonial authorities introduced.

D: It provides an example of a specific country in which colonial property laws have been successfully challenged in court.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is tempting because the passage does discuss solutions (hybrid frameworks), but the underlined portion describes the HISTORICAL SHIFT that caused the problem, not the proposed solution. The solution comes in the last clause. C is wrong because the text does not evaluate which system is better -- it presents the replacement as the cause of conflict, not as an improvement.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Paleontologist Jia Wei has challenged the long-held view that the mass extinction at the end of the Cretaceous period was caused solely by a meteorite impact. Geological evidence shows that massive volcanic eruptions in what is now India -- known as the Deccan Traps -- began approximately 250,000 years before the impact event and continued for another 500,000 years afterward. Wei argues that these eruptions destabilized global climate before the impact and continued to suppress recovery afterward, meaning that the extinction resulted from the combined effects of volcanism and impact rather than either factor alone.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents a timeline that undermines Wei's argument for volcanic involvement in the mass extinction.

B: It identifies the specific location of the volcanic eruptions in order to establish Wei's credibility as a geologist of the Indian subcontinent.

C: It describes a finding that Wei considers peripheral to the central debate about the cause of the Cretaceous extinction.

D: It provides geological evidence that the eruptions overlapped with the extinction event, supporting Wei's multi-causal interpretation.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the hardest trap and requires careful reading. Students might think: "250,000 years BEFORE the impact -- if the eruptions started long before, maybe they are unrelated." But the key detail is they CONTINUED for 500,000 years AFTER, meaning they overlapped with and followed the impact. The timeline actually SUPPORTS Wei by showing the eruptions bracketed the event. Read both numbers, not just the first one.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: The following text is from Rosa Figueroa's 2022 novel *The Unfinished Garden*.

The architect returned to the site every morning, though the client had abandoned the project months ago. She measured angles that would never become walls, sketched rooms no one would inhabit. <u>Her colleagues, all employed on paying commissions, regarded her visits as an eccentricity -- charming at first, then worrisome.</u> But the architect understood something they did not: that the value of a design was not determined by whether it was built.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It provides evidence that the architect's continued work on the abandoned project has damaged her professional standing among her peers.

B: It establishes an outside perspective on the architect's behavior that the text then counters with the architect's own understanding.

C: It explains the financial reasons why the architect's colleagues chose not to continue working on the abandoned project.

D: It introduces a disagreement about architectural aesthetics between the architect and her colleagues that shapes the remainder of the narrative.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the best trap. "Worrisome" suggests concern, which students might read as damaged reputation. But the colleagues' view functions as a FOIL -- it exists so the text can contrast it with the architect's belief in the next sentence (signaled by "But"). The function is to set up the contrast, not to document professional harm. D is wrong because the disagreement is not about aesthetics -- it is about the value of uncommissioned work.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Immunologist Dario Rossi has investigated why certain vaccines produce long-lasting immunity while others require periodic boosters. <u>The prevailing explanation holds that vaccine durability depends primarily on the persistence of memory B cells, which can rapidly produce antibodies when re-exposed to a pathogen.</u> Rossi's research, however, suggests that the structural stability of the antigen used in the vaccine also plays a critical role: antigens that maintain their shape over time continue to stimulate the immune system at low levels, effectively acting as an ongoing booster. This finding has implications for the design of future vaccines.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It presents the accepted understanding of vaccine durability that Rossi's research then supplements with an additional contributing factor.

B: It introduces a hypothesis about memory B cells that Rossi's experiments have definitively disproven.

C: It describes the experimental approach that Rossi adopted before developing his own alternative methodology.

D: It identifies the specific mechanism that Rossi's research has confirmed as the sole determinant of vaccine longevity.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Trick: B is the hardest trap. The word "however" after the underlined portion makes students jump to "he disproved it." But Rossi's finding "ALSO plays a critical role" -- meaning he is ADDING to the prevailing explanation, not replacing it. Memory B cells still matter; Rossi just shows antigen stability matters too. "However" can signal addition or complication, not only contradiction.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Function of Underlined Text

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: Behavioral researcher Nadia Petrov has studied how framing affects charitable giving. <u>Prior research had established that people donate more when presented with a single identifiable victim (such as a named child in need) than when given statistical summaries of large-scale suffering -- a phenomenon known as the "identifiable victim effect."</u> Petrov's experiments added a layer of complexity: she found that donors who were first shown a statistical overview and then introduced to an individual case gave less than donors who encountered the individual case alone. Petrov hypothesizes that statistical framing activates analytical thinking, which dampens the emotional response that drives generosity toward identifiable victims.

Which choice best describes the function of the underlined portion in the text as a whole?

A: It describes the main finding of Petrov's own experiments on charitable giving and framing effects.

B: It introduces a criticism of earlier research methods that Petrov's study was designed to address and correct.

C: It establishes a previously documented pattern that Petrov's research builds upon by revealing an additional complication.

D: It defines a concept that the text ultimately argues has been misidentified and should be discarded by researchers.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Trick: A is the biggest trap. The identifiable victim effect is a real finding about charitable giving, and students might attribute it to Petrov. But the text says "PRIOR research had established" it -- Petrov's OWN finding comes later ("added a layer of complexity"). The function of the underlined portion is to lay the groundwork that Petrov then builds on. D is wrong because the identifiable victim effect is not discarded -- Petrov's work adds nuance to it.

END QUESTION